

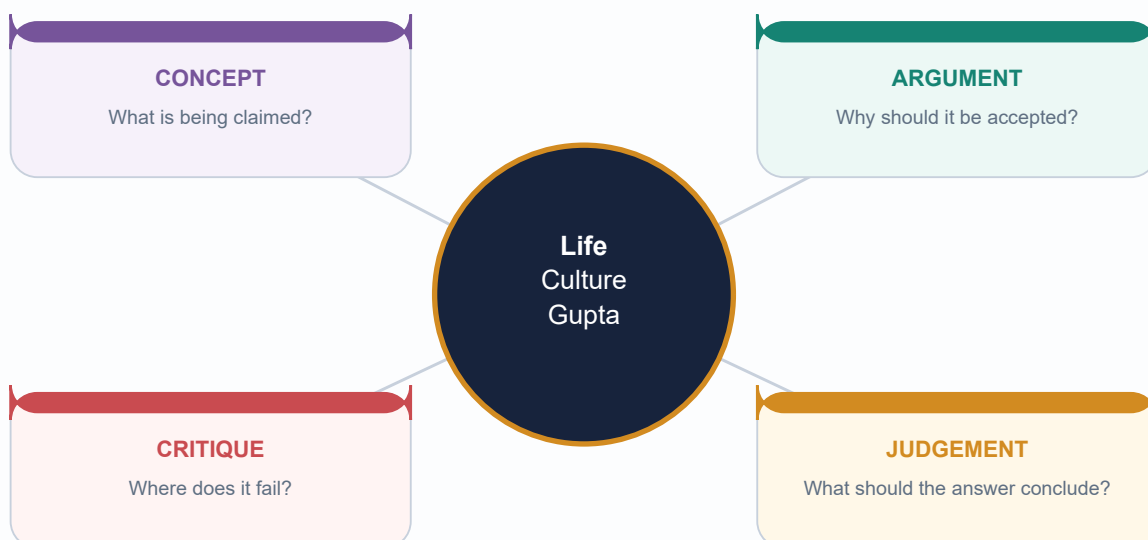
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Life & Culture in the Gupta Age - Solved Practice Workbook

Ancient Indian History | Topic 21 | Prelims and GS-I support

Generated 14 August 2026 | approved=false

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Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Verified PYQ 1 - Prelims 2020 Q29 (direct owner)

Prelims + GS-I

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

With reference to the history of India, the terms "kulyavapa" and "dronavapa" denote: (a) measurement of land (b) coins of different monetary value (c) classification of urban land (d) religious rituals.

STATIC THEORY

- [FACT/LIMIT] Status: INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

- Answer / route: A - measurement of land.

- The terms occur in land-recording and agrarian-measure contexts. The distractors shift them into coinage, urban classification or ritual. Confidence: high.

- Why this earns marks: the solution states ownership, key status, evidence and limitation.

MAINS ANGLE

PYQ solved without inventing official-key status.

STUDY LINK

Owner and cross-owner stated.

HIGH

Verified PYQ 2 - Prelims 2020 Q36 (literature bridge)

Prelims + GS-I

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

With reference to scholars/litterateurs of ancient India: 1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra Shunga. 2. Amarasingha is associated with Harshavardhana. 3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandragupta II. Which statements are correct?

STATIC THEORY

- [FACT/LIMIT] Status: INFERRED ANSWER - OFFICIAL 2020 KEY NOT HELD LOCALLY.

- Answer / route: Statement 3 only; option C in the locally extracted Set A paper.

- Panini predates Pushyamitra; Amarasingha is traditionally associated with the Gupta/Vikramaditya milieu rather than Harsha; the exam convention accepts Kalidasa-Chandragupta II while scholarship still cautions that exact court biography is debated. Confidence: high for exam elimination.

- Why this earns marks: the solution states ownership, key status, evidence and limitation.

MAINS ANGLE

PYQ solved without inventing official-key status.

STUDY LINK

Owner and cross-owner stated.

HIGH

Verified PYQ 3 - Prelims 2021 Q40 (routed demand)Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Locally audited demand: distinguish Mitakshara and Dayabhaga systems of property inheritance.

STATIC THEORY

- [FACT/LIMIT] Status: ROUTED DEMAND; EXACT LOCAL PAPER/KEY NOT HELD. PROVISIONAL CONCEPT SOLUTION, NOT AN OFFICIAL KEY.

- Answer / route: Core distinction: Mitakshara recognises a son's interest by birth in joint ancestral property; Dayabhaga generally opens the son's succession after the father's death.

- Do not treat the schools as Gupta codes. Mitakshara is Vijnaneshwara's later commentary on Yajnavalkya Smriti; Dayabhaga is associated with Jimutavahana. The question is cross-temporal legal history.

- Why this earns marks: the solution states ownership, key status, evidence and limitation.

MAINS ANGLE

PYQ solved without inventing official-key status.

STUDY LINK

Owner and cross-owner stated.

HIGH

Verified PYQ 4 - GS-I Mains 2022 Q12 (cross-owned)Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21**INTRO & ORIGIN**

Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

STATIC THEORY

- [FACT/LIMIT] Status: VERIFIED ROUTING; Gupta culture supported here, Gupta polity Topic 20, Chola context Topic 27, form depth Indian Art and Culture.

- Answer / route: Cross-owned model route.

- Thesis: both periods created enduring cultural repertoires through different political economies. Gupta evidence: Kalidasa, Aryabhata, Sarnath/Mathura sculpture, early structural temples, Puranic plurality and Sanskrit prestige, qualified by regional patronage and social inequality. Chola evidence: Brihadishvara and other Great Living Chola Temples, bronze Nataraja, Tamil inscriptions, temple institutions and maritime-linked patronage, qualified by regional diversity. Comparison: Gupta contribution is especially canonical in Sanskrit literary-scientific and iconic vocabularies; Chola contribution is especially monumental, inscription-rich and temple-institutional. Why this earns marks: balanced periods, named evidence, comparison, qualification and direct discussion.

- Why this earns marks: the solution states ownership, key status, evidence and limitation.

MAINS ANGLE

PYQ solved without inventing official-key status.

STUDY LINK

Owner and cross-owner stated.

HIGH

Verified PYQ 5 - Prelims 2025 Q15 (cross-owned official key)

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of: Samudragupta / Chandragupta II / Kumaragupta I / Skandagupta.

STATIC THEORY

- [FACT/LIMIT] Status: OFFICIAL 2025 SET A QUESTION AND KEY LOCALLY AVAILABLE; PRIMARY OWNER TOPIC 20.

- Answer / route: B - Chandragupta II.

- Faxian travelled c. 399-414 CE, overlapping Chandragupta II. Topic 21 uses the item to teach traveller-source limits.

- Why this earns marks: the solution states ownership, key status, evidence and limitation.

MAINS ANGLE

PYQ solved without inventing official-key status.

STUDY LINK

Owner and cross-owner stated.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 01 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which source pairing best tests a claim about Gupta social hierarchy?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Smriti and inscription

- B. Only a later legend

- C. Only a modern textbook label

- D. Only one coin type

- Answer: A. A prescriptive text establishes the norm; an inscription can test selected public practice.

- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 02 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Kulyavapa and dronavapa are best understood as

STATIC THEORY

- A. guild offices
 - B. land-measure terms
 - C. coin denominations
 - D. marriage forms
- Answer: B. The official 2020 paper asks this exact distinction; they denote measurement of land.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 03 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement is safest regarding Gupta-age women?

STATIC THEORY

- A. All women enjoyed equal inheritance
 - B. Women were absent from production
 - C. Patriarchal norms coexisted with uneven agency
 - D. Purdah was universal
- Answer: C. The evidence supports a differentiated, source-aware conclusion.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 04 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Faxian's account should primarily be read as

STATIC THEORY

- A. a Gupta revenue manual
- B. a complete census
- C. a neutral legal code
- D. a Buddhist pilgrim's situated account
- Answer: D. His route and religious purpose shape both observation and silence.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 05 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Mandasor silk-weaver inscriptions are especially useful for linking

STATIC THEORY

- A. migration, corporate craft identity and patronage
- B. only royal conquest
- C. only village taxation
- D. only Buddhist doctrine
- Answer: A. They connect mobility, guild identity, wealth and temple support.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 06 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is the correct chronology?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Brahmagupta before Aryabhata
- B. Aryabhata before Varahamihira
- C. Varahamihira before Kalidasa with certainty
- D. Vagbhata securely under Samudragupta
- Answer: B. Aryabhata is 499 CE; Varahamihira belongs to the sixth century.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 07 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The strongest caution about Aryabhata is that

STATIC THEORY

- A. he wrote no mathematical work
- B. he denied astronomy
- C. place-value use is not the same as inventing zero
- D. he lived in the Mauryan age
- Answer: C. Zero, place value and epigraphic notation have distinct histories.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 08 - key D

Prelims + GS-I

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Ajanta's major late phase is best described as

STATIC THEORY

- A. Mauryan imperial
- B. Kushana court
- C. Gupta imperial only
- D. Vakataka-context within the Gupta-Vakataka age
- Answer: D. This preserves the political and chronological caveat.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 09 - key A

Prelims + GS-I

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Sanskritisation in this period is best treated as

STATIC THEORY

- A. adoption and local adaptation of prestige idioms
- B. extinction of all Prakrits
- C. one royal language law
- D. proof of universal literacy
- Answer: A. It was negotiated and multilingual.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 10 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Sarnath Gupta sculpture is especially associated with

STATIC THEORY

- A. blue-grey schist
- B. buff/cream sandstone and subtle robe treatment
- C. black basalt only
- D. bronze Nataraja
- Answer: B. The material and modelling distinguish the Sarnath convention.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 11 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which temple claim is safest?

STATIC THEORY

- A. All Gupta temples had later Khajuraho scale
- B. Bhitargaon is a rock-cut cave
- C. Deogarh is an early sixth-century Vaishnava structural temple
- D. Sanchi Temple 17 is a Chola gopuram
- Answer: C. Deogarh is a key early structural and iconographic example.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 12 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Golden Age label is best evaluated as

STATIC THEORY

- A. false because no achievements occurred
- B. a neutral census term
- C. equally valid for every region and class
- D. useful for classical production but socially uneven
- Answer: D. This is the required graded verdict.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 13 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which evidence most directly demonstrates plural patronage?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Udayagiri's multiple religious presences and varied donors
- B. one later court legend
- C. one modern nationalist slogan
- D. absence of all Buddhist sites
- Answer: A. Udayagiri combines Vaishnava royal imagery with Shaiva and Jaina presence.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 14 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Mitakshara and Dayabhaga should be treated as

STATIC THEORY

- A. two Gupta coin series
- B. later Hindu-law commentarial schools
- C. two Buddhist monasteries
- D. two Gupta temple plans
- Answer: B. They are later legal schools and must not be backdated.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 15 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which claim about Kalidasa is most defensible?

STATIC THEORY

- A. His date is fixed by a birth inscription
- B. Every navaratna legend is contemporary
- C. His works are secure but exact court association is debated
- D. He wrote the Aryabhatiya
- Answer: C. The works are firmer evidence than the later biography.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 16 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

A social-history answer should conclude with

STATIC THEORY

- A. a ruler list
- B. a generic heritage slogan
- C. an unsupported quotation
- D. a graded verdict tied to distribution and evidence limits
- Answer: D. The directive requires evaluation, not celebration.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 17 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about the Mehrauli iron pillar is safest?

STATIC THEORY

- A. It proves advanced wrought-iron skill; royal identification remains debated
- B. It is certainly Ashokan
- C. It is a bronze pillar
- D. It proves invention of stainless steel
- Answer: A. Technical skill is secure; ruler identification and modern labels need caution.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 18 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The Mandasor silk weavers most directly demonstrate

STATIC THEORY

- A. imperial conquest
- B. mobility and corporate patronage
- C. absence of urban craft
- D. a Buddhist council
- Answer: B. The inscriptions connect migration, occupation and religious endowment.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 19 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement best distinguishes stridhana?

STATIC THEORY

- A. It was equal modern coparcenary
- B. It abolished patriliney
- C. It was a recognised female property category within varied patriarchal rules
- D. It was a tax
- Answer: C. Recognition did not make the entire property regime equal.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 20 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is NOT a safe Gupta-age claim?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Sanskrit court culture expanded
- B. Buddhism continued
- C. Jain evidence survived
- D. Brahmagupta served Chandragupta II
- Answer: D. Brahmagupta is seventh-century and post-Gupta.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 21 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Sanchi Temple 17 is useful as evidence for

STATIC THEORY

- A. an early flat-roofed structural shrine
- B. a mature Chola gopuram
- C. a Mughal arcuate tomb
- D. a Harappan granary
- Answer: A. It illustrates restrained early structural-temple form.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 22 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which pair is correctly matched?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Bhitargaon - rock-cut chaitya
- B. Sarnath - refined Buddha sculpture
- C. Deogarh - Mauryan palace
- D. Ajanta - Gupta revenue archive
- Answer: B. Sarnath is a major Gupta sculpture centre.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 23 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The term 'Gupta-Vakataka age' is especially useful for

STATIC THEORY

- A. denying Gupta culture
- B. dating Panini
- C. placing Ajanta's late phase without false imperial attribution
- D. identifying Dayabhaga
- Answer: C. It preserves broad chronology and actual patronage context.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 24 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which conclusion is least defensible?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Urban fortunes varied
- B. Sanskrit coexisted with other languages
- C. Royal affiliation was not exclusive state religion
- D. Every subject enjoyed equal prosperity
- Answer: D. The universal prosperity claim contradicts hierarchy and labour evidence.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 25 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which source is most directly prescriptive?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Smriti
- B. terracotta figurine
- C. coin hoard
- D. temple plan
- Answer: A. Smritis set normative rules.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 26 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

A guild endowment primarily indicates

STATIC THEORY

- A. no monetary institutions
- B. corporate capacity to hold/manage resources
- C. complete political sovereignty
- D. absence of merchants
- Answer: B. It shows historically specific financial and corporate capacity.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 27 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Kalidasa is safest?

STATIC THEORY

- A. He certainly wrote every text attributed to Vikramaditya's court
- B. He was a Mauryan minister
- C. Major works are secure; exact biography is debated
- D. He composed Brahmasphutasiddhanta
- Answer: C. Works and later court legend must be separated.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 28 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which answer structure best fits 'critically examine Golden Age'?

STATIC THEORY

- A. only achievements
- B. only inequalities
- C. ruler chronology
- D. achievement, distribution, limits and graded verdict
- Answer: D. Critical examination needs criterion and balance.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 29 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is a strong source-limit sentence?

STATIC THEORY

- A. An inscription records a public claim, not total practice
- B. All inscriptions are false
- C. Texts are irrelevant
- D. Archaeology is complete
- Answer: A. Genre-aware use is neither credulous nor dismissive.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 30 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Aryabhata's eclipse explanation relied on

STATIC THEORY

- A. divine swallowing only
- B. shadows and astronomical reasoning
- C. European telescopes
- D. Brahmagupta's 628 rules
- Answer: B. His astronomy explained eclipses through shadows.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 31 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about language is correct?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Prakrit disappeared
- B. Sanskrit was only spoken by everyone
- C. Sanskrit prestige coexisted with multilingual life
- D. Tamil was created by the Guptas
- Answer: C. Court prestige did not eliminate other languages.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 32 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is the proper ownership statement?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Topic 21 owns all Chola architecture
- B. Topic 21 owns Gupta campaigns
- C. Indian Art and Culture owns no forms
- D. Topic 21 supplies context; form-heavy art remains cross-owned
- Answer: D. Ownership must reflect actual syllabus and source function.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 33 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The strongest use of Faxian is

STATIC THEORY

- A. corroborated situated observation
- B. uncritical empire-wide statistics
- C. a substitute for archaeology
- D. proof by silence
- Answer: A. His account is valuable when route and purpose are stated.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 34 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is correctly paired?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Amarakosha - Aryabhata
- B. Amarakosha - Amarasimha
- C. Meghaduta - Varahamihira
- D. Aryabhatiya - Kalidasa
- Answer: B. Amarakosha is traditionally attributed to Amarasimha.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 35 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

What most directly complicates a universal Golden Age?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Garuda emblem alone
- B. one court title
- C. exclusion and labour obligations
- D. a later legend
- Answer: C. Social distribution is the decisive test.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 36 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which claim requires the strongest caveat?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Aryabhatiya is dated 499 CE
- B. Faxian was Buddhist
- C. Bhitargaon is brick
- D. Nalanda was already identical to its seventh-century form
- Answer: D. Nalanda developed over time.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 37 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Varna should be used as

STATIC THEORY

- A. a normative model tested against jati and occupation
- B. a complete occupational census
- C. a synonym for guild
- D. a temple style
- Answer: A. The model/practice distinction is fundamental.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 38 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The principal value of Ajanta for daily life is

STATIC THEORY

- A. exact population data
- B. rich visual evidence filtered by convention
- C. complete legal rules
- D. Gupta tax rates
- Answer: B. Visual evidence is rich but composed.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 39 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Puranas is safest?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Written in one Gupta year
- B. Only Buddhist
- C. Layered texts with long compilation and redaction
- D. Official land surveys
- Answer: C. Their formation was cumulative.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 40 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

A good 20-mark conclusion should

STATIC THEORY

- A. introduce new facts
- B. avoid the directive
- C. repeat the question
- D. give a graded evidence-based verdict
- Answer: D. The verdict should follow from the demonstrated criterion.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 41 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which named example best links artisans and patronage?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Mandasor silk weavers
- B. Prayag conquest list only
- C. Ashokan Kalinga edict
- D. Uttaramerur assembly
- Answer: A. Mandasor is the relevant Gupta-age corporate example.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 42 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Deogarh is primarily associated here with

STATIC THEORY

- A. a Gupta army camp
- B. an early Vaishnava structural temple
- C. a Buddhist stupa of Ashoka
- D. a Chola bronze foundry
- Answer: B. The Dashavatara temple anchors early sixth-century architecture.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 43 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which comparison is defensible?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Sarnath used only red sandstone
- B. Mathura had no Buddhist art
- C. Mathura and Sarnath differ in material and treatment
- D. Both were Chola centres
- Answer: C. The comparison should avoid caricature while naming real differences.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 44 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

The phrase 'achievement for whom?' tests

STATIC THEORY

- A. only chronology
- B. only iconography
- C. only authorship
- D. social and spatial distribution
- Answer: D. It turns Golden Age into an evaluative question.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 45 - key A

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which route is correct for the 2025 Faxian question?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Topic 20 owns reign chronology; Topic 21 uses traveller method
- B. Topic 21 owns all campaigns
- C. Indian Art owns the reign
- D. Economy owns the pilgrim
- Answer: A. This is the explicit anti-duplication boundary.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 46 - key B

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which statement about Buddhism is safest?

STATIC THEORY

- A. It vanished under the Guptas
- B. It continued through monasteries, pilgrimage and images
- C. It became the sole state religion
- D. Faxian found no Buddhist sites
- Answer: B. Continuity coexisted with Puranic expansion.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 47 - key C

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which scientific figure is post-Gupta?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Aryabhata
- B. Kalidasa
- C. Brahmagupta
- D. Amarasimha with certainty
- Answer: C. Brahmagupta's 628 work is post-Gupta.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Workbook MCQ 48 - key D

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Which is an invalid inference from Prabhavati Gupta?

STATIC THEORY

- A. Elite women could exercise authority
- B. Dynastic position mattered
- C. Female agency was context-specific
- D. All women had equal public power
- Answer: D. An exceptional elite case cannot establish universal status.
- Why this earns marks: the explanation identifies the tested distinction and removes the closest trap.

MAINS ANGLE

Objective elimination with chronology and source discipline.

STUDY LINK

Relevant learning section.

HIGH

Remedial 1 - Zero claim

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Aryabhata invented zero.'

STATIC THEORY

- Aryabhata's 499 CE procedures presuppose decimal place-value logic. The conceptual and epigraphic histories of zero are separate; Brahmagupta's explicit arithmetic rules belong to 628 CE.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the corrected sentence in revision.

STUDY LINK

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH

Remedial 2 - Ajanta ownership

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Ajanta is Gupta imperial painting.'

STATIC THEORY

- The principal late fifth-century phase is chiefly Vakataka-context production within the broader Gupta-Vakataka cultural age.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE*Use the corrected sentence in revision.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH**Remedial 3 - Women****Prelims + GS-I**

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Prabhavatigupta proves women had equal status.'

STATIC THEORY

- She proves specific elite female authority. General status needs normative, inscriptional, labour and property evidence.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE*Use the corrected sentence in revision.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH**Remedial 4 - Faxian****Prelims + GS-I**

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Faxian gives an objective census.'

STATIC THEORY

- He provides situated pilgrim observation. Corroborate route-specific claims and do not infer from silence.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE*Use the corrected sentence in revision.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH**Remedial 5 - Golden Age****Prelims + GS-I**

Ancient History

21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Social inequality means there was no cultural achievement.'

STATIC THEORY

- Critical evaluation preserves achievement while testing its social and spatial distribution.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE*Use the corrected sentence in revision.***STUDY LINK**

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH

Remedial 6 - Temple style

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Gupta temples were mature Khajuraho-style Nagara temples.'

STATIC THEORY

- They represent earlier structural experiments; describe plan, material and superstructure before applying later style vocabulary.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the corrected sentence in revision.

STUDY LINK

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH

Remedial 7 - Mitakshara

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Mitakshara was a Gupta legal code.'

STATIC THEORY

- It is Vijñaneshwara's later commentary on Yajñavalkya Smṛiti; Dayabhaga is also later.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the corrected sentence in revision.

STUDY LINK

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH

Remedial 8 - Sanskrit

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Correct the statement: 'Sanskrit replaced all other languages.'

STATIC THEORY

- It became a transregional prestige idiom while Prakrits and regional speech persisted.
- Why this earns marks: it replaces an absolute claim with a dated, source-bounded formulation.

MAINS ANGLE

Use the corrected sentence in revision.

STUDY LINK

Return to the linked conceptual section.

HIGH

Original solved Mains 1 (10 marks) - Explain how sources shape our understanding of daily life in the Gupta age.

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Demand and thesis (10 marks): Daily life is recoverable only through triangulation because every source overrepresents a particular social world.

STATIC THEORY

- **Evidence density target:** 4-5 named units, each linked to significance.

- **Model answer:**

- [CLAIM] Normative texts reveal household and hierarchy ideals. [EVIDENCE] Smriti rules on guardianship and property. [SIGNIFICANCE] They disclose the elite social order. [LIMIT] They are prescriptive.

- [CLAIM] Traveller observation adds selected practice. [EVIDENCE] Faxian's Chandala passage. [SIGNIFICANCE] It records exclusion. [LIMIT] It is route- and purpose-bound.

- [CLAIM] Images and objects recover material and performative life. [EVIDENCE] Ajanta dress and gesture, terracotta and pottery. [SIGNIFICANCE] They widen the record beyond law. [LIMIT] artistic convention and survival bias remain.

- **Conclusion:** The strongest reconstruction names the source, the social location and the confidence level for every detail.

- **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

MAINS ANGLE

Solved using claim -> evidence -> significance -> limitation.

STUDY LINK

[Practice and answer architecture.](#)

HIGH

Original solved Mains 2 (15 marks) - Analyse the role of Sanskritisation in Gupta-age cultural integration.

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Demand and thesis (15 marks): Sanskritisation created a shared elite idiom but operated through regional negotiation rather than language replacement.

STATIC THEORY

- **Evidence density target:** 6-7 named units, each linked to significance.
- **Model answer:**
 - [CLAIM] Sanskrit connected courts. [EVIDENCE] prashastis and kavya. [SIGNIFICANCE] rulers entered a transregional political-aesthetic field. [LIMIT] inscriptions do not prove popular speech.
 - [CLAIM] Puranic myths and sectarian icons widened cultural repertoires. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Deogarh Vaishnava programme. [SIGNIFICANCE] belief, kingship and sacred space became mutually legible. [LIMIT] Shaiva, Shakta, Buddhist and Jain traditions continued.
 - [CLAIM] Local agents adapted the idiom. [EVIDENCE] regional courts, donors and workshops. [SIGNIFICANCE] integration did not erase locality. [LIMIT] Sanskritisation should not be described as frictionless.
 - [CLAIM] Multilingualism remained. [EVIDENCE] Prakrit and regional speech traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] the process was layered. [LIMIT] literacy and language use cannot be quantified.
- **Conclusion:** Sanskritisation was powerful because it was portable and adaptable, not because it created cultural uniformity.
- **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

MAINS ANGLE

Solved using claim -> evidence -> significance -> limitation.

STUDY LINK

Practice and answer architecture.

HIGH

Original solved Mains 3 (20 marks) - Assess the relationship between religion, royal power and artistic production in the Gupta-Vakataka age.

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
21

INTRO & ORIGIN

Demand and thesis (20 marks): Religion supplied symbols of sovereignty and fields of patronage, while artistic production depended on plural donors, workshops and regional courts.

STATIC THEORY

- **Evidence density target:** 8-10 named units, each linked to significance.

- **Model answer:**

- [CLAIM] Royal Vaishnavism translated power into cosmic order. [EVIDENCE] Udayagiri Varaha and Garuda symbolism. [SIGNIFICANCE] the king could be associated with protection and restoration. [LIMIT] iconography is not a literal political event.

- [CLAIM] Structural temples stabilised deity-centred sacred space. [EVIDENCE] Sanchi 17, Deogarh and Bhitargaon. [SIGNIFICANCE] patronage joined image, ritual and architecture. [LIMIT] chronology and reconstruction differ by site.

- [CLAIM] Plural traditions remained productive. [EVIDENCE] Shaiva and Jaina evidence at Udayagiri, Buddhist networks described by Faxian. [SIGNIFICANCE] royal preference did not eliminate multiple communities. [LIMIT] surviving monuments are uneven.

- [CLAIM] Regional courts were decisive. [EVIDENCE] Vakataka-context Ajanta. [SIGNIFICANCE] the age's finest painting was not simply imperial Gupta output. [LIMIT] cave phases and patrons require care.

- [CLAIM] Non-royal patrons mattered. [EVIDENCE] Mandasor silk weavers and lay donative traditions. [SIGNIFICANCE] merchants and artisans converted wealth into sacred culture. [LIMIT] corporate inscriptions are selective.

- **Conclusion:** Gupta-Vakataka art was a negotiated field where sovereignty, devotion, corporate wealth and workshop skill converged without producing religious uniformity.

- **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, links each claim to named evidence, explains significance, states limitations and gives a graded verdict.

MAINS ANGLE

Solved using claim -> evidence -> significance -> limitation.

STUDY LINK

Practice and answer architecture.